The Fear of Being 'Ordinary'

B1-B2 Speaking club

General Tips:

Please note that the **introduction stage** with the general tips below will take about **3-5 minutes.**

1. Before the speaking club.

Send students their Student's Notes file before the speaking club and encourage them to read the article, review the Quizlet set, and optionally complete the Wordwall task.

2. Set a relaxed atmosphere.

Start with a short informal question for the whole group (for example: *How was your day?* or *What did you do today that was ordinary or routine?*). This helps students switch into English and lowers anxiety.

3. Highlight the goal of the session.

Remind students that the aim is communication, not perfect grammar.

Encourage them to:

- share personal ideas
- react to other students
- ask follow-up questions

4. Mention useful expressions.

Tell students that during the discussion, they should try to use 5–7 expressions from the vocabulary list and pay attention when other students use them.

5. Organise the group.

Explain how students will work (in pairs or small groups) and how much time they will have for each task. Let them know that you will give clear time limits for every activity.

Task 1. Getting to know each other.

Time: 7 minutes.

Instruction: Work in pairs or small groups. Introduce yourself in three sentences (name, age, job, hobbies, etc.).
Then choose one sentence below, complete it, and explain your answer. Listen to others and ask one follow-up question.

- *One small thing that makes my life interesting is...*
- *An ordinary life for me means...*
- *I would be afraid if my life became...*
- *A moment when I felt my life was exciting was...*
- *In the future, I would like my life to be...*

Teaching Tips:

Encourage short follow-up questions (for example: Why?, When was it?, Can you give an example?).
If the group is quiet, model one example yourself.

Examples of follow-up questions:

- *Why?*
- *When did it happen?*
- *Can you give an example?*
- *How did you feel?*
- *What happened next?*
- *Do you do it often?*
- *Who was with you?*
- *Why is it important for you?*

Task 2. What Is an 'Ordinary Life'?

Time: 7 minutes

Instruction: Work in pairs or small groups. Discuss the questions, give reasons and examples, and react to others by asking follow-up questions.

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- What do people usually mean when they say they don't want an "ordinary life"?
- Why do some people feel afraid of living a normal life?
- Do you think social media influences this feeling? How?
- Do people put too much pressure on themselves to have an exciting life?
- Is it possible to be happy with a simple life?



Teaching Tips:

- Encourage interaction between students, not just answering the question.
- Remind students to use phrases from their Student's Notes (e.g. I agree, I see your point, I have a different opinion).
- Ask one student from each group to share one of their ideas with the class after the discussion.

Task 3. Agree or Disagree?

Time: 7 minutes

Instruction: Work in pairs or small groups. Read each statement. Decide if you agree, disagree, or partly agree. Explain your opinion and give an example. Ask another student if they have the same opinion.

1. *An exciting life is better than a calm life.*
2. *Most people secretly want to be famous.*
3. *Happiness comes from big achievements.*

Teaching Tips:

- Encourage students to justify their opinions and remind them to use phrases for discussion from their Student's Notes.
- Monitor the breakout rooms. If the discussion slows down, ask additional questions such as: Can you think of a real example?
- This activity often creates natural debate, so allow some spontaneous discussion.
- For class feedback, nominate one student from each pair/group and ask them to share one idea they agreed on with their partner.

Task 4. What Matters Most in Life?

Time: 7 minutes

Instruction: Look through the list of values and rank them from most to least important to you. Then compare your ideas with your group and try to agree on a final ranking.

- strong relationships
- interesting experiences
- financial stability
- free time
- personal achievements
- helping other people

Teaching Tips:

- Ask students to explain why they placed their top value in position 1.
- Encourage students to use phrases for discussion from their Student's Notes.
- After the discussion, nominate one student from each pair/group to share their ranking.

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Task 5. What Would You Comment?

Time: 10 min

Instruction: Read the post and discuss it in small groups. Imagine you saw this post online. What would you say in the comments?

soman_2026 • 2 days ago

How can I stop worrying about having an ordinary life?

I think about this quite a lot, probably more than I should. Most of the time I feel okay, but every now and then I start worrying that my life is just... average. Like I'm not really doing anything special or memorable. I'm not famous, I'm not super successful, and I most likely won't achieve anything huge that people will remember.

I know it sounds a bit dramatic, and I should just be happy with what I have, but I still end up comparing myself to people who seem more successful or more "interesting" than me.

When I was younger, I was one of the top students in my class, and people always said I'd do something great. And to be fair, my life now is actually pretty good — I've got hobbies I enjoy, I spend time outdoors, I'm into creative things, and I have a job that feels meaningful.

But sometimes I still feel like I've chosen the "safe" option. Like, I see people my age starting businesses, building a following online, or just taking big risks, and I can't help thinking, what if I'd tried that too?

For example, I thought about trying content creation or starting a YouTube channel, but I didn't take it seriously at the time. Now I see people my age doing it successfully, and I wonder if I missed my chance.

I know my life is fine, but part of me feels like I'm just playing it safe instead of really going for something bigger.

At the same time, I worry that my life will just pass quietly and won't really make a difference. I don't want to be someone who looks back and feels disappointed or full of regrets. Maybe I'm overthinking it — I probably am — but I can't seem to switch these thoughts off.

23 2 Share

Teaching Tips:

- Give students a few minutes to read the post individually.
- Encourage students to give advice and share their opinions.
- Ask students to support their ideas with examples.
- For class feedback, ask students whether they would give advice, show general support, or choose not to comment on such a post.

Task 6. Do You Agree With These Comments?

Time: 7 minutes

Instruction: Read the comments. Discuss them with your group. Do you agree or disagree with these opinions? Explain why.

unpaid_wizard_404 • 14 hours ago

I think the key is to rethink what success actually means to you. I used to feel the same way when I was younger. At some point, I realised that real success isn't about being famous or rich, but about having a positive impact on people around you.

Try to be the best version of yourself — as a friend, a partner, a person in general. Just don't forget to set boundaries and not let people take advantage of you. It's important to expect a lot from yourself, but also from the people you trust.

4 Reply Share

plasticmoon23 • 2 days ago

Honestly, you have two options: either go all in and try to do something big, or learn to be okay with a simpler life. Over time, you might realise that just being alive and having a good life is already something valuable. There are so many people struggling, and sometimes we forget how much we already have. Maybe you will do something amazing one day — who knows? But it's also okay if you don't.

Wanting more is normal, but it can also make things feel more complicated than they need to be. In the end, you can either chase something bigger or focus on appreciating what you already have. Both are valid choices. Good luck

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Teaching Tips:

- Encourage students to react to each comment.
- Ask if they mentioned similar ideas in their discussion.

Task 7. My Not-So-Ordinary Life

Time: 5 min

Instruction: Work in pairs. Think of two facts about your life: one true and one invented. Both should be unusual. Tell your partner both facts. Your partner asks 1–2 questions and guesses which is true. Then share one interesting thing you've learned about your partner with the group.

Teaching Tips:

- Give students 1 minute to think before they start.
- Encourage them to ask simple questions (Why?, When did it happen?, Where was it?).
- When sharing with the group, students should talk about their partner, not about themselves.

Task 8. Final thoughts

Time: 5 minutes

Instruction: Think about the discussion you've had today. Discuss the questions below to reflect a bit.

1. *What was the most interesting idea you heard during the discussion?*
2. *Did someone say something that changed your mind or made you think differently?*
3. *Was there an opinion that surprised you? Why?*
4. *Do you agree with most people in the group, or did you have a different perspective?*
5. *What is one idea from today that you will remember?*

Teaching tips:

- Give students a minute to think individually before they start speaking. This helps them organise their ideas and speak more confidently.
- Encourage students to refer to specific ideas or people from the discussion (e.g. "I liked what Anna said about…").
- Highlight good language use or interesting ideas at the end to close the activity positively.

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